Navigating the Political Science Academic Job Market as a PhD Candidate

Isabel Laterzo[1] & Emily Ommundsen[2]

Last Updated: May 15, 2024

This document gives an overview of how you might consider preparing for and navigating the academic job market as a PhD candidate. Below you will find a list of materials that you should compile, some suggestions on how you might prepare mentally, how you might approach networking, what you need to know to actually apply to positions, tips for interviewing, and guidance for negotiating an offer. This document is certainly not exhaustive – and we have included links in the appendix to a number of other useful resources – but is intended to be a helpful place to begin preparing for the several months you will spend on the job market.

[1] isabel.laterzo@austin.utexas.edu
[2] emilyommundsen@gmail.com

Contents

Part 1: Preparing Your Materials **3**
C.V. 3
Cover Letter 3
Writing Sample(s) 4
Research Statement 4
Teaching Statement 4
Evidence of Teaching Effectiveness 5
Diversity/DEI Statement 5
Letters of Recommendation 6
Part 2: Preparing Yourself **6**
Prepare your website 6
Get organized 6
Prepare your job talk 7
Make a plan with your partner/family, if relevant 7
Free up time in the fall 7
Prioritize your mental health 8
Part 3: Identifying Types of Jobs and Scope **8**
Part 4: Networking **8**
Networking at conferences 9
Utilizing faculty connections 9
Other networking 9
Part 5: Applying **10**
Finding positions 10
Submitting materials 10
Waiting for updates 11
Part 6: Interviewing **12**
First-round interviews 12
Fly outs 12
Part 7: Receiving the Job Offer and Negotiating **19**
Negotiating 20
Appendices and Miscellany **23**
Sample job market timeline 23
List of questions to ask when interviewing 24
List of questions to be prepared to answer 25
Additional useful guides 26

Part 1: Preparing Your Materials

Typically, there are eight documents you will need:

1. C.V.
2. Cover Letter
3. Writing Samples (1-2, but you should have 3 ready if you can)
4. Research statement (3 single-spaced pages, on average)
5. Teaching statement (2 single-spaced pages, on average)
6. Diversity/DEI statement (2 single-spaced pages, on average – but this one is the most common to vary in length, often as short as one page)
7. Demonstration of teaching effectiveness (can summarize courses taught, teaching training, teaching evaluations, syllabi)
8. Three letters of recommendation

These may vary in length based on the institution. Begin by writing the “average” length. Adjust as needed. Please see below for additional information on each type of document.

With these documents ready (or at least solid drafts prepared), it is then time to share them with your letter writers. With finalized documents, it can be helpful to prepare a folder (Google Drive) for your letter writers. You might organize the folder by document type (e.g., cover letter(s), writing sample(s), etc) and include a personalized document for each writer including topics they may wish to cover in their letters.

It can be helpful to send your documents to your letter writers early for potential comments. Sending early can be useful because they may be supporting more than one person on the job market. You should aim to minimize the amount of time they will have to rush on your materials by sending them before what we anticipated to be a wave of others. This will also provide you with time to incorporate their feedback prior to any application deadlines.

C.V.

Your C.V. will not change much from application to application. The only piece of your C.V. that you might tailor depending on the application relates to the placement of your “teaching” section. If you are applying to a job that emphasizes teaching (e.g., a liberal-arts job), your teaching section should be above your publications/research section. Search committees view this as a signal that you value teaching and have meaningful experience.

Cover Letter

It can be useful to have a “base” cover letter, but adjust it depending on the school. You can ask for a few alumni of your program and friends who have recently been on the job market if they could share their previous cover letters. These can be useful starting points.

You may end up having two base cover letters – one for research-focused universities and one for liberal arts/teaching-focused schools. Further adjustments can include:

1. Discussing why that school in particular is a good fit for you
2. Demonstrating that you can teach a particular course they are looking for
3. Adjusting the framing of your research depending on goal of search
4. Highlighting why the location of the school is good for you or any connections you might have to that university
5. Emphasizing/not emphasizing teaching
6. Discussing your commitment to DEI or certain relevant values (e.g., if it is a school that shares your religious values, etc.)

Writing Sample(s)

Most schools ask for just one, but some ask for two, and many do not specify. Further, many applications give you the option to add on additional documents. If that is a possibility, it can be useful to include your main writing sample (your "job market paper") in addition to two other writing samples as supplementary documents. Additionally, you can create one PDF document that has multiple writing samples and attach that as your writing sample if the application does not specify the number of samples they'd like. In general, we found it helpful to include as much information as possible.

Your primary writing sample should be a solo-authored piece. Your additional writing samples could be a chapter from your dissertation or a co-authored piece.

You should discuss what your main writing sample should be with your dissertation committee chair and committee members. What the most appropriate writing sample is largely depends on you, what your best work is, and what type of position you are applying for. The document you choose as your primary writing sample will form the basis of your job talk, so it should be very polished and something that is relatively straightforward to present.

Research Statement

Your research statement should be a snapshot of research you've completed, research in progress, and where you see your research agenda heading. The more clearly you can articulate a coherent research agenda, the better. If a job posting lists a particular type of research they're looking for (American presidency, Sub-Saharan Africa, conflict, etc.), be sure to highlight how your research agenda falls within that description. This document is typically three single-spaced pages in length.

Teaching Statement

Your teaching statement serves as an overview of the type of instructor you are/hope to be, and your pedagogical philosophy. If you have taught previously, be sure to highlight that experience, describing ways you might have developed and re-developed syllabi, the variety of instructional

styles you've used, what assignments you've created, etc. This is also a good spot to include some of the highlight reel of your teaching evaluations. Feel free to pull quotes or data from your evaluations to highlight how students appreciated aspects of your teaching.

This document will likely vary depending on the types of jobs to which you are applying. It is common to have several versions, tailored to the specific job description. For example, you might have one version of your teaching statement describing how you would teach at a liberal-arts college, another version describing the graduate courses you could teach, another version articulating how you would teach methods courses, and perhaps another more general version. Much like the research statement, if the job posting clearly states that they are looking for a candidate who can teach a specific course, be sure to highlight how you could fill that need. This document is typically two single-spaced pages, but it is common for job postings to ask for a one-page version.

Evidence of Teaching Effectiveness

This document can take a number of forms. When an application asks for both a teaching statement and evidence of teaching effectiveness, your evidence of teaching effectiveness should consist of your student evaluations of your teaching. We found it helpful to create a sort of "executive summary" of evaluations that preceded our full evaluations. It is a helpful signal to indicate that you have included all of your evaluations and that you are not hiding anything, but evaluations can be hundreds of pages, so you should make the search committee's job easier by pulling out some highlights.

If an application does not ask for a separate teaching statement, you may choose to create a single PDF that contains both your teaching statement and your student evaluations.

Diversity/DEI Statement

This document might be called a number of things, including a "Diversity Statement," "DEI Statement," and "Statement of Commitment to Diversity." Oftentimes, rather than a standalone document, a job posting will ask you to fold this information into a teaching statement or cover letter. In any instance, schools are generally looking for a clear track record of having engaged with diverse communities, how your research might support diverse or marginalized communities, or how you will contribute to the university's mission of inclusivity or diversity. This document should be one to two single-spaced pages.

Note that increasingly, certain states are barring their public universities from evaluating candidates in any way related to DEI. This may explain why an institution does not ask for a specific statement or does not request that you cover this material in your cover letter or teaching statement. You can always, however, include information related to DEI topics in your cover letter if you have certain personal experiences you'd like to bring to the committee's attention. But make sure to check in on any recent developments related to public institutions before you submit any applications.

Letters of Recommendation

If applying to a variety of jobs, it can be useful to ask your letter writers – or at the very least your chair – to prepare multiple versions of letters on your behalf. For example, if you intend to apply to both liberal arts schools and R1s, you will likely want a letter for liberal arts schools that emphasizes your teaching more than the letter you would send to an R1.

Part 2: Preparing Yourself

You've probably heard it many times, but the job market is not fun. We say this simply to emphasize that again. It is very stressful. You are being evaluated constantly – on paper, during conversations, during a talk, while you eat, etc. Beyond professionally, the job market can also affect your personal life. Here are a few things that may help make it not as stressful:

Prepare your website

The summer before applying to any jobs is a good time to create a polished, professional website. The URL should be some form of your name, and it should be easily searchable. Your website should include a home page with a professional headshot, a brief snapshot of your research, and a personal bio. You should also have a "CV" page with an embedded and downloadable copy of your CV, a "Research" page with more information about and links to your work, and a "Teaching" page with a list of courses you've taught or TAed and links to syllabi or course evaluations. Some also include a page with links to your job market materials (research statement, teaching statement, etc.). This can be helpful if someone misplaces part of your file, or if someone at a job talk wishes to read part of your application. It is not required however, and only do so if you are comfortable. You should also make sure that your name, information, and email are all accurately displayed on your department's website.

Some useful website builders/resources include:

- Wordpress: www.wordpress.com
- Github: https://academicpages.github.io/
- Owlstown: https://www.owlstown.com/
- Wix: https://www.wix.com/
- Squarespace: https://www.squarespace.com/

Get organized

Try to make a schedule for yourself and give yourself internal deadlines for things like preparing your materials and submitting applications. Even if you fall off the course of your plan a few times, it can be useful to have built in some extra time on some things (e.g., set internal deadlines for applications a few days before). If you have a family that is used to having you at home, it could be useful to prepare them that you might be gone for some periods for interviews and this could be at short notice.

It can be useful to create a spreadsheet to track both job postings as they are released, and your status of submitting the application and hearing back. Your advisor might ask you to share this spreadsheet with them so they can see where you're applying and what the status of any application is.

Prepare your job talk

In addition to preparing the materials that you will physically turn in with your applications, it is smart to start preparing your job talk in the late summer and begin practicing in the early fall. This talk is typically based on your central job market paper. One way to begin is to start by writing out the flow of your talk, then convert it into slides, and then begin by walking through it orally. Arthur Spirling has some useful resources about the job talk here.

You can ask your friends and colleagues to sit in on practice job talk sessions (both in person and virtual). This is useful to gather their feedback and refine your presentation. If possible, it would also be useful to schedule a "dry run" with your department faculty – some departments organize these, but if yours does not, you can ask your dissertation committee to do a mock run with you. Beyond getting feedback, it is useful during these sessions to practice fielding questions. Tim Ryan has some useful tips on strategies for fielding questions in his job market guide here.

Job talks range between 20-45 minutes depending on the institution (see "Job Talks" below under "Interviewing"). You can start by preparing a 40-minute talk, and then cut or lengthen it depending on the department's requirements if you get an interview. They are typically followed by 20-45 minutes of questions. Keep this in mind while preparing and practicing.

Make a plan with your partner/family, if relevant

Before submitting any applications, it can be helpful to discuss with your partner what constraints you might have. These constraints might be based on geography, salary range, teaching load, rural/urban preferences, or any number of other factors. The important thing in this regard is to ensure that you and your partner are on the same page. Generally speaking, if you get to the stage of receiving an offer, it is extremely unadvisable to turn it down because of a factor that was known in advance (e.g., location or length of post-doc). For that reason, you should generally only apply to jobs where you and your partner would be willing to accept an offer.

Free up time in the fall

If you can secure external funding or a fellowship for your final year to relieve yourself of service (e.g., teaching), it can make things a lot easier. However, this is obviously not possible for everyone. In that case, try to have conversations with your department and advisor about how to handle missed classes or TA sessions that you are scheduled to cover if you get a job talk. If you are in a position where you need to teach, it can be easier to TA rather than teach your own course in the fall in which you are on the market.

Prioritize your mental health

This is different for everyone. For some, options could include finding an exercise class you like, pursuing a hobby, etc. Find what makes you feel most stable, and try to make time for it. If at all possible, find a support network outside the department, but at the very least, outside of your cohort.

Part 3: Identifying Types of Jobs and Scope

Early on, it is also important to think about what types of jobs you are interested in. Do you want to apply for tenure track jobs, post docs, and/or visiting professorships? Is there a type of department (e.g., political science, public policy, international studies, interdisciplinary) or university (e.g., R1, R2, liberal arts) that you are most interested in? Is there a location you are or are not interested in?

Going through this exercise is useful in narrowing down what types of jobs you want. But also, as mentioned above, you will want to try not to apply to jobs you would not take (e.g., if you want to live in the U.S. exclusively, do not apply to jobs in Europe). In other words, only apply to jobs you would accept if given an offer. You will certainly learn more about a school or position during a campus visit, but, in general, if there is a feature about a school that you could have known in advance of your visit that would cause you to turn down an offer, you should not apply. This piece of advice may be up for debate, but you may speak with your advisors and consider it.

This will also affect what materials you do or do not draft. For example, if you do not want to work at a liberal arts school, you will not have to write a cover letter for those positions. Or, if you are exclusively interested in teaching-oriented positions, this will also save you work in drafting research-oriented materials. Further, if you are applying to jobs outside of traditional political science departments (e.g., policy schools, interdisciplinary departments) you will also want to tailor those applications to make it clear as to why you are interested and a good fit for those jobs.

Finally, communicate the scope of your job search to your letter-writers. This is useful information for them to know, and can help them identify positions for you or connections that may be useful. It is acceptable to have boundaries in your career search and to determine places or types of institutions where you would not want to work.

Part 4: Networking

Everyone has different approaches to networking, but here are some general insights. Networking (rather actively) can be useful to develop connections and have some people remember your name on the job market (or at least that is the hope!). It is helpful to begin this process in the years leading up to your time on the market, but it is also very common to attend APSA while on the market and use that conference as an intentional networking opportunity.

Networking at conferences

Before conferences, determine 2-3 people you really want to meet and reach out to them. Maybe they're on your panel, maybe they're not. If job postings are up, this may be someone who is at a department that is hiring. Additionally, some schools will conduct formal interviews at APSA. These will be indicated on the APSA eJobs posting and will list a contact person to reach out to for scheduling.

If schools are not holding formal interviews (or if you attend a conference other than APSA while on the market), you should identify your high-priority positions and attempt to leverage your network to meet with faculty members in those departments. Once you determine who these people are, email them to see if they have time for coffee/a chat. Before doing so, check with your advisor and those that you are close to if they know these people – maybe they can tee you up to chat with them via email. If not, you could then email them on your own. Importantly, some may not think that reaching out "cold" to a faculty member at a department that is hiring is a smart thing to do. There are different views on this, but the worst they can do is not respond or say no. It really depends on the school and the person if they will meet with you. If they say no, that is fine! But if they say yes, that is awesome. A few necessary points:

1. Show up to the meeting on time, if not early
2. Come having reviewed the person's work
3. Come with questions/specific topics you want to discuss
4. Respect the individual's time and do not extend the meeting beyond a predetermined length
5. Send a thank you email

Utilizing faculty connections

Faculty on your committee and in your department more broadly are invaluable tools for networking. This is a small field, and odds are that someone on your committee or in your department knows a faculty member at each school to which you are applying. While it may be unrealistic to expect faculty to use their connections at each school you are applying to, it can be helpful to identify a top five or top ten and ask for help making connections for those particular positions.

Other networking

Beyond formal meetings, just talk to people! This could be at conferences before/after panels, at internal events in your department, or at workshops. Of course, don't interrupt people or their conversations, but there is nothing wrong with going up to someone if they are available and (re)introducing yourself. It can feel uncomfortable. Sometimes people are very receptive. Sometimes they're not – and it is nothing personal.

Part 5: Applying

Tenure track jobs will start to be posted on major job boards in July. The earliest deadlines are in mid to late August. Postdocs begin to be posted in the fall, but vary much more. Some postdocs are not posted until the spring. Visiting assistant professorships and teaching positions also vary much more in the timing of when they are posted.

Finding positions

The majority of tenure-track political science jobs in the U.S. can be easily found on the APSA eJobs site. Many post docs are also posted on this site, but can also be found elsewhere (e.g., directly on a school's website, on social media). You need an APSA membership to access eJobs. Check to see if your department is able to cover the cost of your membership, as they are typically able to get a discount if they register multiple students. There are also a few other sites you should pay attention to that might capture political science-adjacent jobs (e.g., policy schools, business schools hiring in a topic related to your research) and jobs outside the U.S. Here is a non-comprehensive list of a few useful sites:

1. APSA eJobs: https://www.apsanet.org/
2. Higher Ed Jobs: https://www.higheredjobs.com/
3. Chronicle of Higher Ed: https://jobs.chronicle.com/jobs/
4. PS Jobs: https://www.politicalsciencejobs.org/jobs-listing

Each of these websites offers a filtering function to their search, which we recommend *against* using. The way that ads are posted is very idiosyncratic, and you can easily miss an appealing ad depending on if the proper search terms were inputted by the person who uploaded the job posting. It is, therefore, more reliable to simply read the entire list of ads. To make this manageable, we recommend sorting the list of ads by date of posting and checking these sites at least twice a week to see what new positions have been posted.

For post docs, it can be useful to identify certain centers at universities (e.g., PPE centers, International Studies centers, etc.) that hire post docs regularly and to check on their application due dates. Ask around as well about ones that might be relevant to your research.

Submitting materials

Once you've identified jobs, you then have to apply! Typically for tenure-track jobs and many post docs, the majority of schools will request that you submit through Interfolio. One nice thing about Interfolio is that you can have your recommenders submit letters directly to the portal, and then you can attach these recommendations to each application (without you directly opening them – they are kept private). On other sites, it is more ad hoc and your recommenders (or graduate student coordinator) may have to submit recommendations for each application.

Some application portals let you save your progress and others require that you upload and submit all of your materials in one setting. For this reason, it can be helpful to have all of your materials for a given application completed prior to beginning the submission process.

After submitting your application materials, we recommend keeping a list of portal/confirmation URLs and/or log-in credentials. You never know when you might have to re-upload a piece of your application or whether a school might ask for something additional.

Waiting for updates

Once you've submitted your materials, arguably the most tedious, mentally taxing piece of the job market begins: waiting for updates. Schools vary in the amount of time it takes to review applications, so you may be contacted within a matter of days of submitting your application, or you may be contacted for an interview over a month after submitting. Just because you have not heard from a search committee within a few weeks does not mean that you are not being considered for an interview.

It can be tempting to feel like you need to have your phone on you at all times, but very rarely do search committees call with an update. And if they do call and you miss it, it's not the end of the world – they'll leave a message. We say this to free you from feeling like you have to answer every unknown call you get or that you can't leave your phone behind at the gym or to see a movie. It is healthy to turn your brain off from the market stress, so find a way to leave your phone behind and avoid compulsively refreshing your email.

Now, if you do want information about how searches are unfolding, there is a very large political science job market Slack you can join. This Slack channel has a moderator whom candidates can direct message with any updates they receive. The moderator then posts updates in the larger thread (e.g., "UC Berkeley has sent email invitations for zoom interviews for their American Politics search," or "Michigan has extended an offer for their Comparative Politics search and it has been accepted"), essentially providing updates in an anonymous manner. If you'd like to join this Slack channel, reach out to someone who was on the market the year ahead of you and they should be able to add you.

One thing that can be helpful to keep you occupied during this period is to work on your job talk. We discuss further details of this below, but after submitting your application, you could be asked to interview nearly immediately. You should, therefore, be ready to give your talk at a moment's notice.

Regardless of whether you seek out updates or choose to wait to be contacted, remember that the market is idiosyncratic and unpredictable. You could have done everything right and still not receive any invitations to interview. As best as you can, do not take it personally.

Part 6: Interviewing

After submitting applications, you may be contacted to interview for the position. Some schools conduct first-round interviews via Zoom or phone, but some skip this step. All schools, however, will fly candidates out to their campus to complete a final-round interview.

First-round interviews

Increasingly, schools interviewing for tenure-track positions will ask a group of candidates to participate in a Zoom/video call interview. This is typically to help narrow down to a group of 3-5 candidates to invite out for an in-person interview. Occasionally, this step may take other, less-common forms like completing a written interview.

On the early end, you would begin to hear back about Zoom or other pre-interviews in early October. These interviews are typically on the shorter side, taking about 20-30 minutes. You may meet with all or a handful of members of the search committee. The interview may be coordinated by the search committee chair or an administrator (e.g., department coordinator). Oftentimes, they will ask you a set of pre-specified questions that they ask all applicants. You should also be prepared to give a short pitch about who you are, what you research, and why you are interested in the school and position. You will also be asked what questions you have for the search committee, so be sure to have a handful prepared (see the appendix for a list of questions you may be asked and some ideas for questions you should ask). Zoom interviews are also common for post-doc positions, although would happen later in the semester.

Take the call in a quiet space, dress professionally (at least from the waist up!) and have a neutral Zoom background (e.g., wall, bookshelf, etc.). Try not to take these in public places with a lot of noise. If you have trouble finding a quiet place, ask your department if you could reserve a classroom or conference room. Prior to the call, make sure your headphones and video are working – search committees are often on a tight schedule (doing multiple interviews within a few hours), so there is little time for troubleshooting technological difficulties. Make sure to always pause before beginning to answer questions so you don't accidentally interrupt members of the call.

It is a good idea to send a follow-up thank you email to the search committee chair following the interview. It may take a week or more to hear back about if they would like to interview you on campus following a Zoom or written interview. It is acceptable to check in politely with the search committee chair after about two weeks.

Fly outs

Search committees typically invite their top three candidates to campus for a final-round interview (often called a "fly out"). Fly outs are an opportunity for the department to gauge how well you would fit in the department and to evaluate your potential as a colleague. Fly outs are also an opportunity for you to determine whether you could see yourself being happy in that position. You will be interviewed throughout your visit, but you should also be sure to take the

time to ask questions and make observations that will help you make an informed choice, should you receive an offer.

Invitations to complete an on-campus interview begin in early October for tenure-track positions and continue through the fall semester and sometimes into the spring. You will typically receive an invitation from the department chair, but at times it may come from the search committee chair or a representative of the Dean's office. This depends on the structure of the department and/or school. How the date is chosen varies significantly by department – some will give you wide date ranges and ask for you to list your preferences. Others may give you one single option and say that they "hope you can make it work." If you cannot make it work, you can politely state so and ask for an alternative; however, you should be prepared for the fact that they might not be able to make other dates work. Very rigid inflexibility can also be an important indicator of department culture and norms, which is important to note.

Some departments will schedule your fly out quickly (e.g., within a few days of the invitation). Others may be a month or so away. This all depends on the pace of the search, the schedules of the search committee members, and the number of candidates they are inviting to interview. Fly outs can happen through February in certain cases. However, the majority will happen prior to the end of the fall semester.

Fly outs range in length from one full day to about two and a half days. You will typically spend at least one night at a hotel near the campus, most typically you would spend two. A sample schedule is provided below. Note that this will vary depending on multiple factors, but you can plan to be in back-to-back meetings for at least one full day.

Sample fly out schedule

Day 1	
Morning/early afternoon	Fly or drive to campus
Early/late afternoon	Arrive at hotel
Early evening	Dinner with members of search committee/department
Day 2	
8:00 AM	Breakfast with search committee chair or department chair
9:00–9:30 AM	Meetings with faculty
9:30–10:00 AM	Meetings with faculty
10:00–10:30 AM	Meetings with faculty
10:30–11:00 AM	Meetings with faculty
11:00–11:30 AM	Time to prepare for job talk
11:30 AM–12:30 PM	Job Talk
12:30–2:00 PM	Lunch with faculty
2:00–3:30 PM	Meetings with faculty
3:30–4:00 PM	Meet with search committee chair or department chair
4:00–4:30 PM	Meetings with grad students
4:30–5:00 PM	Meet with someone from the Dean's office (e.g., an Associate Dean for the College of Arts & Sciences, Associate Dean for Research, etc.)
5:00–6:00 PM	Break and time to go to hotel
6:00–8:00 PM	Dinner with faculty
Day 3	
Morning	Fly or drive back

Logistics

Typically a department administrator will book your travel (e.g., plane tickets). However, all other costs (e.g., Ubers, taxis, etc.) will often be handled via reimbursement. If you are flying in, you may be picked up at the airport by a faculty member or you may be asked to take a cab. Regardless, all of this information will be communicated to you by the relevant staff person or chair. You should expect to receive your itinerary at least 24 hours in advance of your arrival. Be sure to do some research on the people with whom you will meet. You should, at the very least, know what they study.

Types of Meetings

During your visit, most likely you will meet with the search committee chair, the department chair/head, and a representative from the Dean's office. But, this varies based on school structure.

Group and individual faculty meetings

These meetings are either one on one with faculty members or in groups. It varies greatly if you will lead/steer the conversation, or the faculty member(s) will, but it is always safest to be ready to lead them. Prepare notes/talking points ahead of time for these meetings. You can ask general questions about the department and their work (see the appendix for a list of questions you might consider asking), but it is also a good idea to have some specific points to discuss with them about overlaps in your work and their recent/ongoing research. Make sure you at least know the research topic of each person you meet with, but it is best to have reviewed each of their CVs. One option is to have written down key points about their research in a notebook, print it out and bring it with you, or email yourself notes to review between meetings/during breaks prior to meetings. Many of these meetings will be with search committee members – make sure you are extra prepared for those, as they are the ones who might have the most say in the final recommendation for who will be hired (although this varies vastly by institution and department).

It is highly likely that most, if not all, of your questions will get answered in your first few meetings. Feel free to ask multiple people the same question! It can be helpful to compare responses to get a sense of whether one person's take is consistent with the rest of the department, or if there are split opinions on a given topic.

There are several types of questions faculty and hiring committees are not permitted to ask you. Namely, they are not legally allowed to ask about your marital or family status, disability or health conditions, citizenship status and national origin, age, among other things. For a more comprehensive list of what universities can and cannot ask you, see this resource. Most faculty are well aware of this, but it is possible that someone might slip up and ask. If that happens, try your best to deflect and move the conversation along to another topic. If you want to volunteer information about a partner or family (perhaps because your partner's family lives near the university or if you are curious about schools for your children), you are more than welcome to do so. But universities are not permitted to use this information to make their decision, and it is

possible that learning this information about a candidate could bias a committee as they make a decision.

Department chair/head meetings

In most cases, you will meet one-on-one with the head of the department (or Dean of the school, if you are being hired directly by a school). This is the person who is most likely your main point of contact about the details of the position and the next steps. It is appropriate to ask them about the timeline for the search (e.g., when do you expect to wrap up interviews, when do you expect to make a decision), about support for junior faculty (e.g., how do you support junior faculty as they pursuing getting tenure?), among other topics. If relevant, this is also the person you will want to inform if you are interviewing at or considering jobs at other universities. If they don't ask you directly, you can ask them what information it would be useful for them to know about your interview process. In general, it can be helpful for them to know if you are interviewing elsewhere. Sharing this information with them can also help them keep other timelines you may be working with in mind. It is normal for them to ask for this information, and it is normal for you to share it if you feel comfortable doing so. It can feel awkward, but as long as you don't boast about it, it is generally normal.

Meetings with university administrators

You may also meet with a representative from the administration of the college, school, or broader university. This could be an Associate Dean of the College of Arts and Sciences, someone from the Office for Research, or another member of the broader administration. In general, these people are there to pitch the university and answer your questions, but they likely do not have a huge say in the outcome of the search. But, you never know and it is important to take the meeting seriously and come ready with questions. While you may consider bringing up any major university changes (e.g., major policy changes at the university level, like those regarding tenure) you might want to wait to have those conversations only until you get a job offer – before that point, it is in your best interest to avoid ruffling feathers or indicating that you are worried about working at the institution.

Job talk

The job talk is the main event of this visit. This is where you will present your job market paper in presentation format. Note, however, that some departments may ask you to present a specific piece of your work, or tailor your presentation to a certain audience (however, this is not particularly common). In most cases, this will be the job talk you prepared earlier in the semester and one that you have worked on and practiced with colleagues and faculty in your department for several weeks, if not months.

It is usually the case that all faculty who are able, will attend your talk. It is also not uncommon for graduate students to attend job talks. If you do not have meetings with all the department's faculty, this might be your only opportunity to make an impression on them. Your talk is an avenue through which attendees can learn about your research, see your teaching style, and get a sense for you as a potential colleague. It is the single most important piece of a campus visit, and should be taken extremely seriously.

The environment of job talks varies vastly by department. Some departments ask few questions at all. Others interrupt your presentations for full substantive questions. Some only ask clarifying questions during the presentation, and save substantive questions until the end. It is acceptable to ask the department chair what the typical style of the job talk is prior to your visit so you can best prepare.

Some say that the Q&A session is the most important part of the job talk – it is where your potential future colleagues get to interact with you, understand your thought processes, and see how you think on your feet. If there are grad students in the room, make sure to take their questions just as you would professors – people will notice if you avoid them or treat them as lesser than other colleagues in the room.

Importantly, departments and professors vary vastly in *how* they ask questions. Some are quite supportive, while some questions can feel like they are trying to see how you work under pressure. It can be helpful to ask your committee or people in your department if they know the reputation of the department at which you will be interviewing, or even the reputation of specific faculty in that department.

Practice both “easy” and “hard” questions to ensure you are prepared for either. It is also helpful to practice getting interrupted to feel comfortable answering questions in a concise manner without getting flustered, while getting back to your talk quickly. For hard questions, many times the question asker simply wants to see how you act on your feet – even if you don’t know the specific answer, you can treat questions like a thought exercise. For example, you could walk the audience through how you would address the question in future research if you had the opportunity, or what the pros and cons are of exploring a certain issue via different methods. Make sure to keep your tone even and upbeat – you can push back on certain questions or ideas floated by the audience. Justify why you are pushing back, but avoid getting overly defensive.

Teaching demonstration

Sometimes in lieu of (or in addition to) a job talk, departments will ask you to prepare a teaching demonstration. Unsurprisingly, this is more common at liberal arts or teaching-oriented schools. A teaching demonstration can take a number of forms: you might be asked to teach part of your dissertation to a group of faculty and advanced undergraduates, you might be asked to teach a topic of your choice to an established class, or you might be asked to teach a particular day of a syllabus to a class meeting that semester. Teaching demonstrations may be anywhere from 20 minutes to an hour or so, depending on what the department is looking for and the length of a class you are teaching.

No matter what the format, be sure to get information about who will be attending the demonstration, what you should anticipate the people in the room will know, if there were any assigned readings for the day (if you are teaching a day from the syllabus), if you can assign a reading, and what technology you will be able to use. As with the job talk, if you are using any

technological materials, be sure to have several methods of accessing them in the case of faulty technology.

You should do your best to treat this demonstration as a display of your pedagogical philosophy. If, for example, in your teaching statement you discuss your use of active learning, it would be wise to avoid lecturing for the whole length of the demonstration. Some candidates find it helpful to bring tent cards and ask attendees to write their names so you can use “students’” names, like you would in a normal classroom setting. This depends on what you are comfortable with.

Meals and social events

You will likely have two dinners, a breakfast, and a lunch with faculty and/or graduate students. You might even have a happy hour with the department. While it can be tempting to treat these parts of your visit as a social event, it is important to keep in mind that you are still actively interviewing and being evaluated.

At dinners, it is common for faculty to order an alcoholic beverage. You are by no means expected to drink, but it would be appropriate to order one if others at the table do so (so, if no one is ordering a drink, you probably should not either). If you do choose to drink, follow the host’s lead, but a general piece of guidance is to stay one drink behind the table. Typically, candidates will stop at one drink.

Some meetings may be held over coffee – be careful overall about your caffeine intake over the day, and try to stay in line with your typical caffeine intake on a normal day. You want to avoid getting dehydrated and/or jittery, and, especially as you will have limited breaks and be talking over your meals, you may have less food in your system than usual so caffeine may affect you differently.

Following Up

Once the fly out is complete, you should make sure to write thank you emails at least to the department chair/department head, chair of the search committee, and search committee members. You may write additional thank you emails to faculty with whom you had longer conversations or someone you really connected with, but these are not necessary. You will probably meet with over 10 people, so realistically it may be difficult to write everyone. It is also important to thank the staff person who helped coordinate your visit. Try to make these emails at least somewhat personalized – for example, you could highlight part of your conversation that you enjoyed, why you feel you are a good fit for the department or university.

Tips and tricks

As you will likely have two days of meetings/meals, be sure that you have at least two well-fitting, comfortable, professional outfits. If you are being picked up at the airport, be sure to wear something semi-professional while traveling, as your interview begins the moment you step off the plane. It can also be helpful to have outfits that are less wrinkle-prone. Most hotels will have an iron, but you may want to pack a travel steamer if your clothes need steaming. Be

sure that the shoes you choose to wear are shoes that you can walk in, as it is common to have walking meetings or campus tours. Pack bandaids if you think you might get blisters. Feel free to express yourself via your clothing (e.g., a colored blouse or a patterned tie), but remember that this is a professional interview, so you should follow professional norms (i.e., wear a blazer).

Be sure to have your job talk accessible via multiple methods (save it in your dropbox, upload it to overleaf, email it to yourself, have it on a flashdrive, etc.). It can be helpful to ask whoever is coordinating your visit what technology you will have access to for your talk and what manner of accessing your slides will be easiest, but you should be prepared with multiple options.

Rarely will you have breaks scheduled into your longest day, but do not be shy about asking to get water or use the restroom. You might want to pack some granola bars or quick snacks in your bag to eat in those few minutes of downtime. Fly outs are long days, and you need to do your best to stay mentally sharp and energized.

Part 7: Receiving the Job Offer and Negotiating

After the job talk, the waiting period for news about whether or not you got the job begins. This waiting period varies greatly based on where you were in the order of interviewed applicants, faculty meeting schedules and votes, holidays, and university bureaucracy. Job offers and/or general news could come anytime between one week and two months (or more) after your interview. It is appropriate to ask the department chair what the timeline is for the search so you can get a sense of how long you might be waiting. It is also appropriate to follow up with the department chair if you have not heard any updates by the time they told you that you could expect to hear.

Departments will typically classify candidates in two ways. First, whether you are “above the bar” or “below the bar,” meaning whether they would be willing to hire you (above the bar) or not (below the bar). Among the “above the bar” candidates, they will typically rank them – that is, who the first offer(s) would go to, the second offer if the first person declines, and so forth. The department may also decide that they will not hire you, not because you did not beat “the bar,” but because the department’s needs have changed, something changed within the search parameters, or other factors entirely out of your control.

If you are the department’s first choice, you should hear first. If you are below the bar, they may let you know that you will not be getting an offer. If you are above the bar, but not the department’s first choice, you may hear nothing for a while. Some departments may tell you very clearly that you are the second or third choice. In these cases, you can then ask what the time frame would be as to when you should hear if they will be extending an offer to you or not (should their first choice decline). Typically, schools will give you two weeks to negotiate and make a decision on an offer – you can sometimes get them to extend that by about a week. If you know, however, that you will not be accepting an offer (e.g., you may have received another offer that you find more appealing), it is polite to let the department know as soon as possible that you will not be accepting.

It is common for the department chair to call you to let you know that you will be receiving an offer. They may spell out some of the terms of the offer over the phone, but you will always receive a written copy of the offer. A job offer will contain six important pieces of information:

1. Salary
2. Start date
3. Teaching load, including possible course releases
4. Tenure timeline (sometimes called “probationary period”)
5. Start-up/research funds, often including a relocation budget
6. Deadline for accepting the offer

Once you’ve received an offer, you should show it to your advisor and other members of your committee, and potentially your department chair, if you feel comfortable doing so. All faculty have, at one point or another, received offers, and possibly extended offers. They know what a typical offer looks like and what might be unusual. They will also help guide you as you begin negotiating the terms of your offer.

Negotiating

Regardless of whether you received one or multiple offers, you should negotiate. If you do have multiple offers, or even if you’ve been on multiple flyouts but do not yet have a second offer in hand, now is the time to use that leverage. Now is also the time to reach out to schools where you’ve had campus visits but haven’t yet received an offer. It is appropriate to let them know that you have another offer in hand and would like an update on their timeline. But even if you do not have other offers on the table, you should still see how much flexibility the department has and negotiate when possible. It is expected!

It is helpful to identify the handful of areas that are most important to you. Perhaps this is your research budget because you anticipate conducting several surveys or field work, or perhaps this is your start date if you’d like to take a post doc before beginning your tenure-track position. Whatever the case, you are more likely to get the department/college to budge if you identify a few key areas of importance, rather than asking for several things.

If the department has recently hired another junior faculty member, it can be useful to reach out to them to see how their negotiating experience was and whether they were able to get some of the things you might be interested in. Some universities absolutely will not budge on course releases, but might be more flexible with research budgets, for example. In any case, this is useful information to have. It is also important to identify who is controlling the outcome, whether that is the department chair or dean.

One other piece of information gathering that is critical before beginning the negotiation process is finding information about salaries. If the university is public, they are required, by law, to report salaries. In some states this is easier to find than others, but it is always publicly available. The American Political Science Association has also collected some discipline-wide

statistics on salaries, which can be helpful to see if your offer is in an anticipated ballpark, or if you might be able to negotiate it up based on what other universities are offering.

This resource provides a recent (but not comprehensive) list of start-up packages for those who received offers at various institutions. This article is also useful reference material for negotiating.

Below is a list of things that you might be able to negotiate:

1. Higher salary
    a. A standard increase is 5-7% from what was initially offered, but be reasonable and use salary data from peer institutions as leverage
2. Summer ninth(s) (1/9 of your salary to be paid during the summer)
    a. Sometimes universities can offer a summer ninth in the summer prior to you starting, but it is also not uncommon to receive summer ninths in your first few summers
3. Additional research funds
    a. If you choose to ask for more research funds, you should itemize a budget and justify why you need more
4. Book conference
    a. Note that this may be lumped into your overall research funds
5. Support for grant writing
6. Course releases
7. Control over which courses you'll teach
8. TAs for your courses
9. RAs for your research
10. Specific computer/hardware
    a. Clarify prior to negotiating whether technology costs come out of your research account or if there is a standard package that will be given to new hires
11. A fellowship year or deferring for a fellowship/post doc, if you get one
12. Spousal career support
13. Courtesy appointments with other departments or research institutes on campus
14. Increased relocation costs
    a. It is helpful to get quotes from movers to be able to say "my move will cost $XX"
15. A "house-hunting" trip to visit the town prior to moving there
    a. Price out what a hotel, flight, and rental car might cost you for a visit and either ask for a specific dollar amount or see if the department will reimburse you

Once you've spoken with your advisor and identified a list of items you wish to negotiate, let the department chair know that you are excited about the offer, but have a few points you'd like to discuss. Now is also the time to ask the chair about parental leave policies, if that is something that you anticipate will matter to you down the line. Oftentimes the chair will want to have this conversation over the phone, but be sure to send your requests in writing and receive any responses or counter offers in writing.

After speaking with your department chair, they will likely need to take your requests to the dean for approval. It might only take a few hours to hear back, but it might also take a few days, depending on the dean's accessibility. It is common to go back and forth once or twice, but rarely will you engage in more than two rounds of negotiating. The department chair will likely make it clear when they have presented their best offer, at which point you should sign if you have no competing offers.

Congratulations! You've survived the job market.

Appendices and Miscellany

Sample job market timeline

April	● Attend MPSA and do some intentional networking
May	● Attend department workshops about preparing for the market
June	● Begin drafting application materials, including website ● Maybe attend a subfield relevant conference and network (e.g., PolMeth, LASA)
July	● Confirm who will be writing your letters and determine what information they'd like from you and when they'd like to have it ● Send materials to your advisor for their review ● Maybe attend a subfield relevant conference and network (e.g., PolMeth, LASA)
August	● Begin preparing the slides for your job talk ● Check job boards for job advertisements
September	● Attend APSA and do some intentional networking ● Submit applications ○ Some are due on 9/1 ○ 9/15 is by far the biggest deadline for applications ● Give a practice job talk by the end of the month ● Check for post doc advertisements that will begin to be posted
October	● Attend campus visits ○ Some occur beginning in mid October
November	● Attend campus visits ○ Most flyouts happen in November
December	● Negotiate and finalize any offers ○ Most are completed before the end of the year ● Submit post doc applications ○ Some are due at the end of the year, but they will continue to be posted through the spring

List of questions to ask when interviewing

Faculty

1. What are you working on now?
2. What do you like best about working in this department?
3. What's the departmental culture like? How has it changed in your time here?
4. Do faculty tend to collaborate with one another? With undergraduate/graduate students?
5. Are there opportunities/venues for faculty to present their research and get feedback?
6. What has your experience as a [relevant demographic of interest (e.g., junior woman/POC/non-binary person/etc.)] been like in this department/university?
7. What are the students like here?
8. What do you do in your free time?
9. What are the tenure expectations?
10. How/how much does the department consider student teaching evaluations in tenure decisions? (SLAC)
11. Where do you live? (if the school is remote)
12. What's the typical class size?
13. Are there certain classes the department has an acute need for?

Administrators/department chair

1. How do you view the Political Science Department in the scheme of the broader college and university? What do you view as the strengths of the department?
2. Where do you see the Political Science Department heading in the next few years? Are there any particular changes/goals/expansions you foresee?
3. What are the department's upcoming hiring goals?
4. What is the relationship between the Political Science Department and the university/college?
5. What opportunities exist for encouraging and facilitating undergraduate research?
6. How big is the major's student body? What are the main demographics of the major's student body? Are they concentrated in particular sub-fields?

Students

1. Can you tell me a little bit about the structure of your program?
    a. Funding, coursework requirements, methods sequence, time to comps/ABD, average time to graduation, recent placements?
2. What courses do you need (substantive or methodological) that aren't being taught?
3. How big are your graduate seminars, on average?
4. Do you often collaborate with faculty on projects?
5. What is your favorite thing about this program? What parts of the program do you think could be improved?

List of questions to be prepared to answer

First-round interviews

1. If you had a one-million dollar research budget, how would you use it?
2. Tell me about your research.
3. What is your next “big” project?
4. How would you translate your research findings into a policy recommendation for someone in Washington, D.C. tomorrow?
5. What is the most policy relevant finding of your research?
6. Why do you study X and Y country? Why is that relevant to your research, and not other countries?
7. Do you consider yourself a generalist or a country expert?
8. Why are you interested in our school?
9. What departmental and university resources do you need to conduct your research?
10. How do you see your research fitting within [subfield]?
11. What courses would you be most excited to teach? What are courses you *don’t* want to teach?
12. Tell me about your dissertation? Where do you expect to publish it?
13. What big questions motivate your research?
14. What do you see as some rewards and challenges of teaching?
15. How have you practiced public engagement in your research?

Fly outs

1. What is your timeline for publishing your book?
2. I can’t attend your talk, can you give me a 30 second summary?
3. Tell me about your research
4. Would you be comfortable teaching classes related to institutions, behavior, or both?
5. Would you be willing to teach X, Y, Z class?
6. What are some influential books in [subfield] that have been published in the last 5 years?
7. What reservations do you have about working here?

Additional useful guides

Other job-market guides

- https://github.com/sysilviakim/sysilviakim.github.io/blob/master/docs/job-market-postmortem-2020.pdf
- https://callahummel.com/wp-content/uploads/2018/06/Political-Science-Job-Market-Guide-Draft.pdf
- https://www.paulmusgrave.info/advice-for-ph-d-job-seekers-in-political-science/
- https://docs.google.com/document/d/1FL5118AQYJTwQTJ73H0QkS8tHf9k8l1qtMq8nPuc-Oo/edit
- https://fbaum.unc.edu/placement/TRyanJobMarketTips2014.pdf

Guide for preparing the job talk

- https://github.com/ArthurSpirling/jobtalks

Tips for negotiating start up packages

- https://www.cambridge.org/core/journals/ps-political-science-and-politics/article/wow-i-didnt-know-these-options-existed-understanding-tenuretrack-startup-packages/2D4EBC319921435782EA95109E223C90

Twitter threads on a plethora of job-market topics

- https://twitter.com/LB_Klein/status/1542208213998772225